

Moonsea Rising!

Like all great empires, “progress” in the Moonsea Empire proceeds at the behest of a select few, the elite. Those select few, great men and women though they may be, are driven in turn by small things: whimsy, greed, fear, disease, love, or a perfectly timed and executed bit of violence.

This campaign is designed to give you a chance at rising to great heights, certainly high enough to join that select few who can change the fate of an empire. Don’t worry, we’ll get a chance to run our blades through fantastic beasts, detect secret doors, and, sure ... ok, yes, cast fireball.

Playing the Game

But...the deadliest game you will play is the game of politics. Indeed, the men and women who engage in political intrigue and tactics in the Moonsea Empire call it “Playing the Game.” Although some of the more ethical players argue that it is bad form to visit dire consequences on someone who is not “in the Game”, everyone agrees that once a person joins the Game, all bets are off.

You are about to join the Game. You will investigate (and maybe even help form) secret alliances, match wits with senators and diplomats, and play dirty pool against some of the most skilled spies in the Moonsea region.

To what end? Well, that’s for you to decide. Perhaps your group will avert a civil war, or start one! You may work to curb the power of the military, or promote the influence of the clergy (Praise be to the Sun and Storm!). Save an emperor, join a coup, install a puppet regime, or just get filthy rich off the chaos while pretending to do one or all of these things: Your choices are many.

No matter your goal, the order of the day is action, espionage, and intrigue. You are dashing elites who sip exquisite drinks in formal clothes one night, only to crawl through the mud and cut down enemies the next.

A Story of Greatness!

When the adventure starts, you will have little, if any, political power (although you can spend a feat at character creation to start as a member of one of the powerful noble families of Melvaunt). You may be minor nobles, merchants, clergy, or even commoners, but through your adventures, associations, and possibly the largesse of the gods, you may rise to become some of the most important figures in all of the Moonsea Empire.

This campaign uses special custom backgrounds to help players craft characters more likely to take part in the kind of story we are telling. These custom backgrounds - Minor Noble, Moonsea Patriot, Senatorial Hopeful, and several others - are merely jumping off points for the collaboration to come. The story is ours to tell together!

It’s a Weeks-Long Party!

We will begin our shared story in the glittering capital city of Melvaunt, during the Festival of the Ascension. This weeks-long party celebrates the rise of the empire’s Founder, Edric Storm, to the

throne and, so the history books tell us, his apotheosis to the status of a demigod. Melvaunt is a city of extremes; despite being among the wealthiest in all of Faerun, it hosts one of the largest populations of destitute and homeless residents. While they share a city, each population leads very different lives, separated by wealth and tradition more than stone walls.

The Festival of the Ascension provides a motivation for characters to gather in Melvaunt, even if they must travel from the far-flung comers of Moonsea or beyond to do so. Minor nobles, ordinary citizens, and even peasants try to make the trip at least once in their lives to see the capital at its most convivial. Even citizens from Baldur's Gate, Memnon, Westgate, and Marsember make the long trip to Melvaunt to enjoy the fireworks, parades, feasts, and sporting events that fill the weeks leading up to the Ascension. Entertainers from across the Moonsea region journey to Melvaunt to capitalize upon the cheap food and generosity the festivities encourage.

Tourists and opportunists alike can find the same appeal in the spectacle of the Ascension, but the weeks are business as usual for the year-round flow of trade. Melvaunt's port sees an endless succession of trading ships arriving from and departing toward destinations all over Faerun. With so many important people all in the same place, this is a time when important treaties are signed and trade deals negotiated against a background of wine, music, and raucous color. And just as Melvaunt attracts politicians and strangers, it attracts schemers and criminals aiming to take advantage of both.

The Feast of the Ascension!

The weeks-long Festival of the Ascension climaxes in a grand ball, presided over by the Stormlord and held in the Asberyth, a massive complex that hosts both the Moonsea Senate and the world-famous Senatorial Archives. The Feast of the Ascension always features a Who's Who of Moonsea nobility and celebrity. The emperor gives a speech. The Senate takes a ceremonial vote to kick off the summer session. And one commoner gets chosen to be elevated to the status of minor nobility. Very exciting!

Adding to this year's excitement are rumors that the Moonsea senate will take up the vote during its next session on whether to repeal the three laws governing succession to the Storm Throne: The Race Law, The Sword Law, and the Storm Law. These laws — denying the throne to anyone who is non-human, a former High Stormreaver, or unrelated by blood to Edric I, respectively — each have their supporters and detractors.

Of course, the senate will not choose any of these highly controversial issues for the symbolic first vote of the session that takes place just before the Stormlord's speech. But the gala represents a prime opportunity for the support and opposition of the various laws to "whip" the vote; to push and cajole and, if necessary, coerce senators and their influencers to the desired outcome.

While some factions may favor the repeal of one or more of these laws, the Imperialists can be counted on to staunchly oppose any changes to the laws of succession. Indeed, Lord Storm has made it obvious to all that he sees the desire to overturn these laws as a direct attack on his crown. Some Imperialists fear that such a vote would be the first step towards an attempted coup. And with no heir apparent, the stakes couldn't be higher.

Regardless of which side of the issue a given citizen supports, nearly every Moonsea native is passionate about the vote, and waiting for the results with bated breath.

Wherever your character hails from, two things bind you to your fellow adventurers: a keen interest in the fate of the Moonsea Empire and a woman named Lady Martella Longtooth. Whatever brought you to Melvaunt — your own political ambitions, a contest victory, a diplomatic mission, or something else — also earned you the attention of this young schemer looking for fresh talent for her own growing web of intrigue.

In exchange for your service, she offers coin, new clothes, and invitations to one of the most prestigious social events of the year: the Feast of the Ascension. Anyone in Moonsea needing a favor, an ear to bend, or a patron can find one during this annual event, as senators and nobles alike gather for hours of food, wine, and music, as well as for official senate business to be conducted before the Stormlord arrives to formally exalt one lucky citizen to nobility. No matter your feelings on the busywork the Lady Longtooth has in mind, these invitations represent rare access to high society and networking opportunities that can change the courses of lives.